

COMMENTS REGARDING URGLAawe FUNERARY RITES

1. Pre-Ceremony: This portion is still a bit difficult to describe. In terms of the legal rights that the Sippschaft has to perform funerary rites per our religious freedoms, there is much work to be done. Funeral pyres are currently not legal in Pennsylvania. Funerary rites of some traditional Deitsch groups include a delayed disposal of the body, which is a practice that Distelfink Sippschaft would like to embrace. These rites include keeping the body in the home for three days.

During those three days, it is believed that the soul is present near the body, and the family is to continue to tend to the body's needs because the soul still feels a connection to it. The body is washed daily. Food is brought into the room. The family sings songs to it. People visit to make their peace with the departed. We are not easily in the position to make this practice a full reality, but it is a tradition that is consistent with Urglaawe belief. Thus, we should make preparations to help to realize our goal of taking care of our deceased members as well as the living folk.

Spiritually speaking, Urglaawe mysticism, with its roots in Braucherei, should be employed to ensure that any fractured portions (especially the portion that is reborn) of the deceased's soul are in the position of being able to progress. This includes site visitations.

It is also important for the community to provide food, transportation, and other essentials to the loved ones of the departed. This is a function of Fruchsfriede (frith) that must not be ignored.

2. Der Barick - (the Barrow): The barrow was constructed by a member of the Sippschaft. Pictures of the barrow are below.





All color selections in the paint come from Braucherei's well-described funerary lore. Although most Brauchers were buried, the applications and representations of color may easily be applied to pyres. At the end of the ceremony, the barrow (or the body) is first wrapped in red cloth (death), then in yellow or green (physical body becoming commended to nature), then black (the transition), then white (the rebirth). The wrapped barrow is then placed into the pyre.

3. Roonfaahne - (Rune Banners): Rune banners are used frequently in Urglaawe. Colors employed are typically those of hex sign color conventions, but funerary rite banners employ a combination of the hex sign convention and Braucherei colors.

The red (death) banner bears a white (freeing of energy) Raidho rune, representing the great journey.

The green banner bears a yellow Jera rune. Braucherei utilizes either yellow or green to represent the physical body's return to the Earth. This aspect also contains a "loose soul" concept, meaning that the physical body and the ethereal body are separated, with (at least) one part of the soul continuing on its journey. In hex sign conventions, the yellow also represents the connection to the divine. The Jera, in this case, represents the stage of the life cycle. In Urglaawe lore terms, this is the reaping by Holle.

The black (transition) banner bears a white (free-flowing energy) Kenaz rune. This represents the mystery of transformation, the ongoing fire of the soul, and the casting of light before the soul on its journey to Holle's Mill.

The white (rebirth, free-flowing energy) banner contains a blue (spirituality) Ingwaz rune. This represents the germination of the eternal part of the soul into a new body.

During processional, the red banner leads, the barrow follows, then come the green, black, and white banners. On the way from the Hof to the bonfire, the red banner leads, the green banner follows, then comes the barrow, then the black and white banners. This order represents the stages of the soul during the ceremony.

4. Der Schmaus - (the Feast): This is an integral segment of any Urglaawe ceremony. In the case of funerary ceremonies, the departed is to be given a plate full of food and a cup from which to drink. The same applies to the Ziewe (deities) and to the Wichde (wights). The food for the departed will ultimately be cast into the fire after the barrow has burned. The food for the Ziewe and for the Wichde may be handled in whatever ceremonial fashion each Sippschaft or Freibesitz deems appropriate.

5. Es Leichtfeier - (Memorial Pyre): The moment of silence is very important. It allows the participants time to collect their thoughts, to grieve, etc. After the Ziewer (gothi) breaks the silence, participants are encouraged to sing songs, to read poems, etc.

6. Die Reiniching - (Cleansing): This practice comes into Urglaawe directly from Braucherei. A strong decoction of black birch/sweet birch is made and allowed to steep for nine hours. Each participant is to drink a sip of this tea and/or have some sprinkled on his/her head. Urglaawe uses both, with the sprinkling consisting of the drawing of a rune (typically Elhaz or Dagaz) on the forehead. The closest of kin (particularly the spouse) is to be fully doused in this tea. Braucherei typically had

the dousing take place during the funerary rite, but colder weather allows for it to be applied as a rinse after bathing.

7. Die Gedechniszettel - (Memorial Tickets): Braucherei tradition holds that any person who has a grievance towards the deceased must make peace at the time of the funeral. One method (among several) states that the participant should place a coin into the gravesite or fire in order to close open wounds. Urglaawe has embraced this tradition but uses paper if a pyre is involved.

The participants are welcomed to write their resolutions to any conflict or to include any prayers or final thoughts on the paper. If the paper is folded, then the message is between that person and the deceased. If the paper is unfolded, then the message is among that person, the Ziewe, and the deceased. The papers may be tossed into the barrow or directly into the fire.

8. Follow-Up: Subsequent site visits may be required. The community should continue to call upon or to correspond with the family members, provided that such communication is welcomed.